

Rocks and minerals

The Earth's crust is made up of different rocks. Some of these are hard but others are soft and crumbly. They are formed in different ways.



Serpentine is a mineral that stone carvers use to create works of art.



Gabbro is a rock that is used to make kitchen surfaces and floors.



White mica is a mineral that you can find in some kinds of toothpaste.

What is a rock?

A rock is formed from minerals. Most rocks are made up of different minerals, but some contain just one. There are three main types of rock: igneous, sedimentary, and metamorphic.

Fossils in stones
Fossils are the remains or imprints of plants and animals that died millions of years ago, preserved in stone.



The rock cycle

Over millions of years, the rocks in the Earth's crust can gradually change from one type into another. They are transformed by wind, water, pressure, and heat.



Igneous rock

Igneous rocks are made when hot molten magma from the Earth's interior cools and solidifies. Some harden underground like granite. Some erupt first as lava in a volcano.



Sedimentary rock

Wind and water wear rocks away. Small pieces, called sediments, wash into the sea. These settle into layers, which pack together to form sedimentary rocks, such as limestone and sandstone.



Metamorphic rock

Sometimes rocks are crushed underground, or scorched by hot magma. Then they may be transformed into new rocks such as marble, slate, and gneiss.